

BEFORE YOU LAND™

First 30 Days in America Planner

A week-by-week mission plan for your first month — with trackers, fill-in pages, and zero guessing about what comes next.



Created by **Nii Obodai** × **Travedconsult.com**

SURVIVAL KIT BONUS · PRINT ME

COMPANION TO THE SURVIVAL GUIDE

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How this planner works

Your first month has about twenty tasks that matter. Spread across thirty days, they're easy. Discovered all at once in week four, they're a crisis. This planner spreads them.

- **Each week has a theme, missions, and a "you'll know you won when" line.** Tick missions off as you complete them. Skip what doesn't apply; nothing here is homework.
- **Fill-in pages** at the back hold your key contacts, accounts, and first-month budget — the information you'll otherwise dig for at the worst moments.
- **Print it or use it digitally.** Paper on the fridge works wonders for accountability. So does a roommate asking why Week 2 isn't ticked yet.
- Chapters in *The Ultimate International Student Survival Guide* explain the how behind every mission — references included.

DAY 0 · BEFORE OR UPON LANDING

The setup missions

- ☐ **Documents folder in carry-on** — passport, I-20, SEVIS receipt, admission letter, insurance, prescriptions
Guide Ch. 1
- ☐ **Message home:** "Landed. Alive. Will call after sleep."
- ☐ **Screenshot tonight's address** and how you're getting there
- ☐ **Fill in the Key Contacts page** at the back of this planner — before you need it

WEEK 1 · DAYS 1-7

Exist officially

Theme: get on the grid. Everything else this month depends on this week.

- ☐ **Get a U.S. SIM/eSIM working** (Day 1-2)
Guide Ch. 10 — everything needs a U.S. number
- ☐ **Report to your international office & complete SEVIS check-in** — before the deadline
Guide Ch. 4 — this keeps your status active. Non-negotiable.
- ☐ **Attend orientation** — all of it, even tired
friends, answers, free food
- ☐ **Get your student ID card** and install the campus app
- ☐ **Walk your class route** before classes start — find the actual rooms

- ☐ **First grocery run + the boring essentials** (bedding, toiletries, lamp)
- ☐ **Locate your four anchors:** grocery store, pharmacy, campus clinic, transit stop
- ☐ **Start the bank account mission:** gather documents, book an appointment

Guide Ch. 5 — no SSN needed at most banks

YOU'LL KNOW YOU WON WEEK 1 WHEN...

Your phone works, your school knows you've arrived, and you can find food, medicine, and your classes without a map.

WEEK 2 · DAYS 8-14

Money & motion

Theme: stop bleeding fees, start moving like a local.

- ☐ **Open your U.S. checking account** — ask about student fee waivers, Zelle, and disabling overdraft
Guide Ch. 5
- ☐ **Move first-semester money** from home through official channels — compare transfer fees first
- ☐ **Sort your transit:** student transit pass, campus shuttle schedule, or a used bike + good lock
Guide Ch. 11
- ☐ **Confirm your health insurance is active** and save your member ID card photo + the nurse hotline number
Guide Ch. 9
- ☐ **Set up your study base:** library card, quiet spots scouted, syllabus deadlines into your calendar
Guide Ch. 14 — the syllabus is a contract
- ☐ **Interested in on-campus work?** Apply now — jobs go fast
Guide Ch. 15; it's also your SSN path
- ☐ **Have the roommate conversation:** cleaning, noise, guests, shared costs
Guide Ch. 8 — ten awkward minutes, twelve peaceful months

YOU'LL KNOW YOU WON WEEK 2 WHEN...

You have a working U.S. debit card, a way to get around, proof of insurance on your phone, and every deadline of the semester in your calendar.

WEEK 3 · DAYS 15-21

Put down roots

Theme: turn logistics into a life.

- ☐ **Join one thing.** A club, team, faith community, or your country's student association — attend once
Guide Ch. 19 — belonging is logistics first
- ☐ **Go to one professor's office hours** — introduce yourself, ask one real question
Guide Ch. 14 — this is where mentorship starts
- ☐ **Find your international grocery store** and cook one meal from home
Guide Ch. 12 — good for wallet and soul
- ☐ **Start the credit conversation:** ask your bank about secured or student credit cards
Guide Ch. 6 — start the clock early
- ☐ **Learn your safety net:** campus security number saved, emergency alerts signed up, safe-ride shuttle understood
Guide Ch. 18
- ☐ **Say yes to one invitation** you'd normally skip

YOU'LL KNOW YOU WON WEEK 3 WHEN...

At least one person on campus greets you by name, and one professor knows your face.

WEEK 4 · DAYS 22-30

Systems & review

Theme: make month one a routine, not a miracle.

- ☐ **Do your first budget reconciliation:** fill in the Money page — what did month one actually cost?
the first month is always the most expensive; now you know your real baseline
- ☐ **Set up autopay** for phone and any recurring bills
Guide Ch. 6 — payment history is everything
- ☐ **Create your LinkedIn profile** (or update it with your new program)
Guide Ch. 17
- ☐ **Visit the career center once** — even just to learn what they offer
- ☐ **Plan one small exploration:** a neighborhood, museum, or town nearby — you live here now, see it
- ☐ **Call home properly** — not the "I'm busy" version. Tell them a real story.
- ☐ **Review this planner:** tick the stragglers, forgive the skipped, book time for what's left

YOU'LL KNOW YOU WON THE MONTH WHEN...

A stranger asks you for directions — and you answer without opening your phone. Congratulations. You're not arriving anymore. You live here.

FILL-IN PAGES

Key contacts

Fill this in during Week 1. Future-you, in a stressful moment, says thank you.

INTERNATIONAL OFFICE / DSO NAME

MY U.S. PHONE NUMBER

DSO EMAIL & PHONE

MY U.S. ADDRESS

SEVIS CHECK-IN DEADLINE

LANDLORD / HOUSING OFFICE

CAMPUS SECURITY

NEAREST CONSULATE/EMBASSY

CAMPUS HEALTH CENTER

EMERGENCY CONTACT (HOME)

INSURANCE MEMBER ID / NURSE HOTLINE

EMERGENCY CONTACT (LOCAL)

REMEMBER

Emergencies: **911**. Mental health crisis line: call or text **988**. Non-urgent campus issues: campus security above.

FILL-IN PAGES

Accounts & setup tracker

Track what's open and what's pending. (Keep passwords in a password manager — never on paper.)

Item	Status / date done	Notes (bank branch, plan name, etc.)
U.S. SIM / phone plan		
SEVIS check-in		
Checking account		
Savings account		
Zelle activated		
Health insurance confirmed		
Student ID card		
Transit pass / bike		
Library card		
Secured / student credit card		
On-campus job application		
SSN (once work-eligible)		
State ID / license		
LinkedIn profile		
Renter's insurance		

FILL-IN PAGES

My first-month money page

Fill the "planned" column in Week 1 and the "actual" column in Week 4. The gap between them is your real education.

Category	Planned	Actual	Notes
Rent / housing			
Move-in & deposits			
Room setup (bedding, kitchen, etc.)			
Groceries			
Eating out / social			
Phone			
Transport			
Books & course materials			
Health / pharmacy			
Everything else			
Total			

MONTHLY BUDGET GOING FORWARD

EMERGENCY CUSHION GOAL

FILL-IN PAGES

Month one, in your own words

Answer these at the end of Day 30. You'll be glad you did — this page becomes a time capsule.

THE HARDEST MOMENT SO FAR WAS...

THE BEST SURPRISE WAS...

PEOPLE I'VE MET THAT I WANT TO KNOW BETTER

SOMETHING FROM HOME I'M KEEPING ALIVE HERE

ONE THING I'LL TELL THE NEXT STUDENT WHO LANDS

GOALS FOR MONTH TWO

Stay connected

Created by **Nii Obodai** — say hello, ask your questions, and tag me when you land. I read everything.

CO-CREATED WITH Travedconsult.com — study abroad, made simpler

WEBSITE www.theniiobodai.com **EMAIL** info@theniiobodai.com

INSTAGRAM · TIKTOK · X @theNiiObodai

YOUTUBE theNiiObodaiLive **FACEBOOK** Nii Obodai

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